to put the next emperor on the Chrysanthemum Throne.[1]

Meanwhile, the military government headquartered at Kamakura, run by a regent on behalf of the figurehead shogun, grew slowly more tyrannical. After the Mongols were driven back, the *shikken* Hojo Tokimune and his successors began to act more and more autocratically: granting government positions to friends and allies, distributing land to loyalists, electing more and more Hojo clan members to be the military governors (the *shugo*) who ran the provinces farther away from Kyoto and Kamakura.[2]

As the grip of the Hojo fist tightened, lawlessness ballooned. Highwaymen flourished. Gangs of outlaws called *akuto* ("evil bands") roamed across the countryside. Pirate fleets haunted the ports and shores. To each problem, the Hojo answered with more force, more regulation, and more punishment. Additional warriors were sent to each *shugo,* tasked specifically with hunting down outlaws. All ships were forced to register and to show the name of the owner and the port of registration at all times. Muggings on land and robbery at sea, once punishable with exile, were now capital offenses. Stealing crops before harvest, once a civil matter, now became a crime.[3]

And yet the disorder grew worse and worse. Piracy moved west, with fleets of ships sacking, stealing, and kidnapping along the coasts of China and Goryeo. The hordes of the *akuto* increased year by year, until the bands were often a hundred strong, armed with swords and bamboo spears, robbing villages and blocking roadways. "They pay no attention to the laws of the *bakafu* [the Kamakura shogunate], and the attempts of the *shugo* to suppress them have borne no fruit," writes a fourteenth-century priest from Harima. "In this way, their numbers have swelled with each passing day." Reports from the outlying provinces complained of night raids and roadside murders, burned farms and stolen crops, temples closed because the monks were too afraid to stay.[4]

IN 1318, THE EMPEROR HANAZONO ABDICATED. He was a son of the senior line, and so his cousin Go-Daigo, who belonged to the junior branch, was crowned the next emperor.

But his enthronement came with conditions. The two years before Hanazono's abdication had been taken up with an increasingly bitter argument between the families. Although Go-Daigo was clearly next in line, most of the junior branch preferred his nephew, Kuniyoshi; but the principle of alternating succession meant that, after Go-Daigo, the crown would have to pass to the other clan, cutting Kuniyoshi out completely.

To prevent a total breakdown at Kyoto, the *shikken* in Kamakura ordered a compromise. Go-Daigo would be coronated, but none of his sons would be